

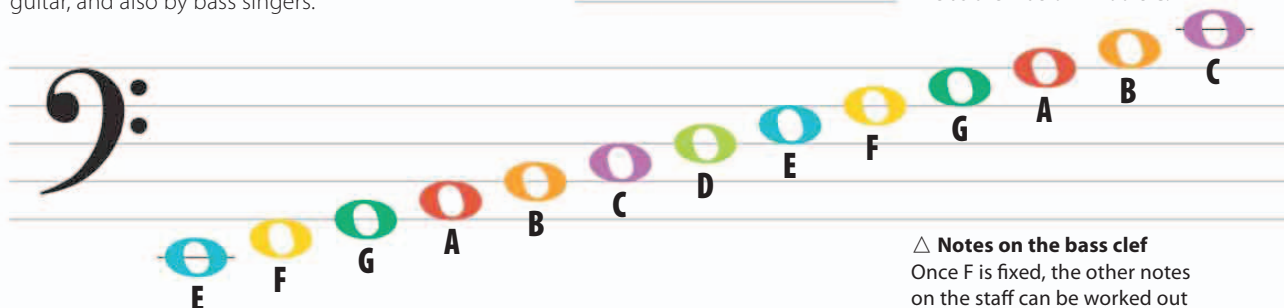
The bass clef

The second most common clef is the bass clef, which is also known as an F clef. The bass clef is used by many low-pitched instruments, including cello, bassoon, timpani, and bass guitar, and also by bass singers.



◁ The F clef

The note on the second line down is the F below Middle C. The bass clef is placed on the staff with two dots on either side of this line, fixing that line as the F below Middle C.

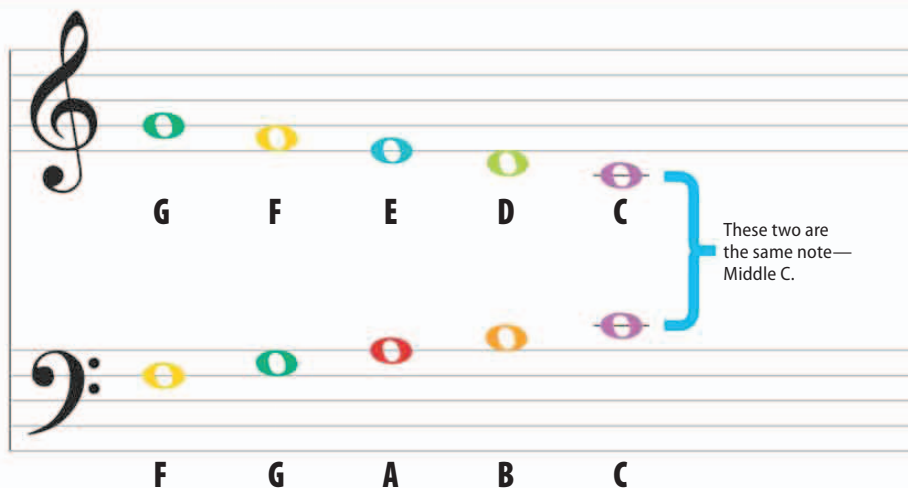


△ Notes on the bass clef

Once F is fixed, the other notes on the staff can be worked out by going forward or backward through the musical alphabet.

Both clefs together

The treble and bass clefs are often paired. The combination of these two clefs is very common and useful, because it covers the ranges of most voices and many instruments.



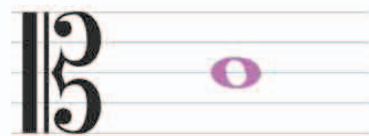
▷ Writing Middle C

Middle C is written on the first ledger line below the staff with the treble clef. Or it is written on the first ledger line above the staff with the bass clef.

LOOKING CLOSER

C clefs

The third type of clef is a C clef. Its center, where the two curves meet, points to Middle C. A movable clef, it sometimes points to the middle line of the staff, where it is called an alto clef. When it points to the second line down it is called a tenor clef. The line that it points to is always Middle C.



△ The alto clef

This clef fixes Middle C on the central line of the staff. It is regularly used by viola players, as it suits the range of their lower strings.



△ The tenor clef

This clef fixes Middle C on the second line down. It is sometimes used by cello, bassoon, or trombone players, when they are playing their higher notes.